documentation of his exploits on a series of boulders—as historical evidence of his enlightened ways.

By the time Ashoka was emperor, Buddhism had been adopted by many Indians who also rejected the use of money, according to their interpretation of Siddhartha’s teachings. The wave of Buddhism had also reached many thousands of people in nearby Sri Lanka and Central Asia, with it later spreading to other parts of Asia. Feeling a strong moral obligation to patronize the Indian Buddhism schools, Ashoka invested lavishly in the Buddhist network of monasteries and spiritual leaders. He commissioned great, beautiful temples across his lands at which the many Buddhists of the empire could convene, take refuge, and establish a true, organized religion. The stupas erected by Ashoka were meant to mimic the original burial mounds of the scattered ashes of Buddha. Though these were eventually eroded with time, many of Ashoka’s stupas were rebuilt and stand today as a symbol of Buddhism’s golden era in India.

With their emperor turning to Dhamma, the people of the Mauryan Empire flocked to their local Buddhist monasteries to claim their own love of Dhamma and begin a new spiritual path. The monasteries were flooded, in fact, so much so that India’s Buddhist leaders arranged to host the Third Buddhist Council at Pataliputra, near the Ganges, in 250 BCE; the first reason for the gathering was to address the tens of thousands of new members who held conflicting beliefs or lifestyles to that of the strict Dhamma proposed by its leaders. It seemed that because of the immense influx of wealth suddenly streaming into the temples from none other than the emperor, people all over the empire had decided to join the rich new faith and rejoice in nothing more than its material benefits.

Following the Council, Buddhist leaders in the Maurya Empire and abroad were instructed to question each of their monks personally, so as to ascertain whether he was even familiar with the concepts of Dhamma. Those who had no answers were removed from their posts and monasteries, thus purifying the Buddhist movement of thousands of unqualified members. Emperor Ashoka, for his part, became a true Buddhist ruler in every way he saw fit—he waged no wars for dominance, he stopped his household from eating all but a small quantity of meat, and genuinely tried to meet the basic needs of his subjects. As he inscribed in the Major Rock Edicts, "Whatever exertion I make, I strive only to discharge debt that I owe to all living creatures."